

CUSTOMER SUPPORT POLICY
Last updated: January 2025

OVERVIEW

Our goal is to provide fast, effective, and friendly support for every customer. This document explains the support channels available to you, our response time commitments, how we prioritize requests, and how to get the most out of your support interactions.

1. SUPPORT CHANNELS

1.1 Live Chat

Available on our website and mobile app. Live chat connects you directly with a support agent during business hours. Our average first-response time via chat is under 2 minutes. After business hours, chat is handled by our AI assistant, which can resolve common issues instantly. Complex after-hours requests are escalated to a human agent and resolved by the start of the next business day.

To access live chat: click the chat bubble icon at the bottom right of any page on our website or tap "Support" in the mobile app menu.

1.2 Email Support

Email us at support@shopexample.com. We respond to all emails within 24 hours on business days. For faster routing, include your order number in the subject line. Email support is best suited for non-urgent issues, detailed inquiries, attaching photos or documents, and tracking ongoing cases.

1.3 Phone Support

Phone support is available Monday through Friday, 9:00 AM to 6:00 PM (Eastern Time).

Toll-free number: 1-800-555-0199

Our average hold time is under 5 minutes. For complex issues, we may offer a callback rather than placing you on hold.

1.4 Help Center (Self-Service)

Our Help Center at help.shopexample.com contains hundreds of articles, step-by-step guides, and video tutorials. Topics include order management, returns, account settings, payment methods, and product use. Most common questions can be answered without contacting an agent.

1.5 Community Forum

Our community forum allows customers to share tips, ask questions, and connect with other users. Forum moderators and our team monitor the forum and respond to unanswered questions within 2 business days. The forum is not monitored for urgent issues.

1.6 Social Media

We monitor direct messages on Twitter/X (@ShopExample), Instagram, and Facebook. Social media is best for general questions and feedback. For account-specific issues, we will ask you to contact us via a private channel to protect your data.

2. BUSINESS HOURS

Live chat (human agents): Monday to Friday, 8:00 AM to 8:00 PM Eastern Time
Phone support: Monday to Friday, 9:00 AM to 6:00 PM Eastern Time
Email response window: Within 24 hours on business days
AI assistant (chat): Available 24 hours a day, 7 days a week
Help Center: Available 24/7

We observe the following U.S. public holidays, during which human support is unavailable (AI and Help Center remain available):

- New Year's Day
- Memorial Day
- Independence Day (July 4)
- Labor Day
- Thanksgiving Day
- Christmas Day

On days immediately preceding or following a major holiday, response times may be extended.

3. RESPONSE TIME COMMITMENTS (SLAs)

We categorize support requests by urgency:

3.1 Critical (Response within 1 hour during business hours)

- Payment failures or unauthorized charges
- Account compromised or suspected fraud
- Order shipped to wrong address (high value orders)
- Unable to access account and time-sensitive order pending

3.2 High Priority (Response within 4 hours during business hours)

- Order arrived significantly damaged
- Missing items from a delivered order
- Incorrect item received
- Subscription billing error

3.3 Standard (Response within 24 hours)

- General product questions
- Return and refund status inquiries

- Shipping and tracking questions
- Account settings and preferences
- Promotional code issues

3.4 Low Priority (Response within 48 hours)

- Feature suggestions and product feedback
- General website feedback
- Non-urgent billing history questions

4. SUPPORT TIERS

4.1 Standard Support

Available to all customers. Includes access to all support channels during business hours, the Help Center, and community forum.

4.2 Priority Support (Premium Customers)

Customers with an active premium subscription or qualifying order history receive Priority Support, which includes:

- Dedicated phone queue with shorter hold times
- Priority handling in the live chat queue
- Assigned case manager for ongoing complex issues
- Response time SLAs upgraded by one tier (e.g., Standard issues resolved within 8 hours instead of 24)

To check if your account qualifies for Priority Support, log in and go to Account > Membership & Benefits.

4.3 Business and Enterprise Support

Customers with a Business or Enterprise plan receive a dedicated account manager, 24/7 phone support, and a guaranteed 4-hour response SLA on all issue categories. Contact your account manager or email enterprise@shopexample.com for support.

5. HOW TO SUBMIT AN EFFECTIVE SUPPORT REQUEST

Providing the right information upfront speeds up resolution. Include:

- Your order number (format: ORD-XXXXXXX)
- The email address associated with your account
- A clear description of the issue (what happened, when, and what you expected)
- Screenshots or photos, if applicable
- What you have already tried

The more context you provide, the faster we can help without back-and-forth.

6. CASE MANAGEMENT AND ESCALATION

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6.1 Case Numbers

Every support request receives a unique case number. Reference this number in all follow-up communications to ensure continuity. Case numbers are sent in the confirmation email or chat transcript.

6.2 Escalation Process

If you are not satisfied with a resolution or feel your issue has not been addressed properly, you may request escalation in any of the following ways:

- Reply to your support email and type "ESCALATE" in the subject line
- Ask the live chat agent to transfer you to a supervisor
- Call 1-800-555-0199 and press 9 at any time during the menu for escalation

A senior agent or team lead will review your case and follow up within 2 to 4 business hours.

6.3 Dispute Resolution

If an escalation does not resolve your issue to your satisfaction, you may submit a formal dispute by emailing disputes@shopexample.com. Formal disputes are reviewed by our Customer Experience leadership team within 5 business days.

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7. ACCESSIBILITY SUPPORT

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We are committed to supporting customers with disabilities. Options include:

- TTY/TDD: 1-800-555-0200 (relay service available)
- Large-print instructions available on request
- Alt text and screen reader compatibility on our website
- Extended response time accommodations for customers who need more time to provide information

Contact us to discuss your accessibility needs, and we will do our best to accommodate.

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8. PRIVACY IN SUPPORT INTERACTIONS

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All support interactions are handled in accordance with our Privacy Policy. We may record phone calls and save chat transcripts for quality and training purposes. We will never ask for your full credit card number, social security number, or account password. If you are ever asked for this information by someone claiming to represent us, do not provide it and report it immediately.

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9. FEEDBACK AND QUALITY

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After your support case is closed, you may receive a short satisfaction survey. Your feedback helps us improve. Agents are evaluated on resolution quality, response time, and customer satisfaction scores. If an agent provided exceptional service, you can request to leave positive feedback on their file.

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10. KNOWN ISSUES AND STATUS PAGE

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We maintain a public status page at status.shopexample.com where we post real-time updates on:

- Website and app outages
- Payment processing issues
- Delays in email or notification delivery
- Carrier-wide shipping disruptions

Check the status page before contacting support for issues that may be affecting all customers.